

SUDDEN DEATH - ASHCOMBE OBSERVATORY

INCIDENT	26-01-0117	REPORTED	07:14 WED 07 JAN	OFFICER	PS G. ORMEROD
LOCATION	ASHCOMBE OBSERVATORY	SUB-LOCATION	MAIN DOME	DECEASED	HALE, Prof. E. (62)

CIRCUMSTANCES

At 07:14 the caretaker, Thomas BRACKLEY, telephoned to report that the observatory's director, Professor Edmund HALE, was lying dead on the floor of the main telescope dome.

Mr Brackley states that he found the dome door bolted from the inside at about 07:05. He fetched a crowbar from the plant room and forced the door at 07:10. The bolt keeper was torn from the frame. He found Professor Hale at the foot of the observing platform ladder.

The dome has one door. The only other opening is the observing slit in the roof, which was open to the sky and is six metres above the floor. **The room was locked from the inside, with the deceased alone in it.**

SCENE

The deceased lay on his back on the steel floor plate beside the base of the platform ladder. The platform is 2.4 m high and is reached by a vertical steel ladder. The dome is unheated; the scene thermometer read -3 C. The dome lights were off; his head torch was on, battery nearly flat. His laptop was open on the platform desk, screen asleep. His spectacles were found under the platform.

OFFICER'S SUMMARY

Professor Hale was working alone in a locked dome at night, in the cold and the dark, on a ladder. Injuries are consistent with a fall from the platform (see B-1). No third party could have entered or left the dome. **Provisional finding: accidental death.** Referred to the coroner. No further police action.

Reopened 02 MAR. The deceased's sister has written to the coroner stating that her brother "had climbed that ladder ten thousand times." Referred to the Case Review Unit with the coroner's consent.

POST-MORTEM EXAMINATION - HALE, EDMUND

CASE	OCME 26-0031	DECEDENT	HALE, E. 62 M	EXAMINED	08 JAN 10:20
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INJURIES

1. Occipital (back of the head). Linear fracture of the occipital bone with an overlying laceration, 40 mm. Consistent with the back of the head striking a hard, straight edge, such as the edge of the steel floor plate.

2. Vertex (crown of the head). A circular depressed fracture, **34 mm across**, with a **fine criss-cross patterned abrasion** on the scalp over it. Attributed to the head striking a ladder fitting during the fall.

Either injury could have caused death. Bruising around both injuries shows that both were received while he was alive.

OTHER FINDINGS

No defensive injuries. No injury to the hands or wrists. Blood alcohol nil. Toxicology negative. Mild coronary artery disease, not contributory.

TIME OF DEATH

The body lay in an unheated dome at about -3 C with the roof slit open. Cooling in these conditions is too fast and too uneven for a useful estimate. **Death occurred between about 23:00 on 06 January and 03:00 on 07 January.** Any narrower time must come from other evidence.

CONCLUSION

Cause of death: head injury. **Manner:** provisionally accidental, on the police account that he was alone in a room locked from inside.

Note. A person falling from 2.4 m would usually strike the head once. Two head injuries on opposite surfaces of the skull, one of them patterned, are unusual in a fall. I have accepted the police account of the scene.

T. BRACKLEY - CARETAKER

INTERVIEWEE	BRACKLEY, T. (57)	DATE	07 JAN	COMMENCED	10:15
STATUS	WITNESS	INTERVIEWING	PS G. ORMEROD	ROLE	CARETAKER, LIVES ON SITE

- TRANSCRIPT BEGINS 10:15 -

PS O Take me through this morning.

TB I come up from the cottage at seven every day to check the boilers. The professor's coat was still on the hook, so I knew he'd stayed up there all night. I went to the dome to see if he wanted tea and the door wouldn't open.

PS O Wouldn't open how?

TB Bolted. There's a keypad lock and a hand bolt on the inside. I put my code in, the lock clicked, and the door still didn't move. That's the bolt. So I knocked, I shouted, nothing.

PS O And then?

TB I got the bar from the plant room and forced it. Ten past seven, about. Tore the keeper clean off. He was lying by the ladder. I rang you straight away.

PS O Was anyone else in the building overnight?

TB Dr Lindqvist was using the control room, the Swedish gentleman. He'd gone by the time I came up. The student went home before midnight.

PS O Did you speak to anyone last night?

TB No. I was in bed by eleven. Nobody rang me.

PS O You look after the door system?

TB I do. I'll print you off the dome door log. It'll show nobody went in after the professor.

- TRANSCRIPT ENDS 10:31 -

DR I. LINDQVIST - VISITING RESEARCHER

INTERVIEWEE	LINDQVIST, I. (39)	DATE	07 JAN	COMMENCED	14:40
STATUS	WITNESS	INTERVIEWING	PS G. ORMEROD	AFFILIATION	UPPSALA, VISITING FELLOW

- TRANSCRIPT BEGINS 14:40 -

PS O You were here last night.

IL All night, in the control room. I run the telescope from the computer there. Edmund was up in the dome with the optics. He liked to tinker while I imaged.

PS O When did you last see him?

IL About ten o'clock. He sat with me in the control room for an hour, then went up to the dome. After that I did not see him again.

PS O Did you go up to the dome at any point?

IL No. Never. I was at my desk the whole time. My imaging sequence ran until about two in the morning and I watched every frame come in.

PS O Did you leave the control room at all?

IL Once, at about quarter to one, I went out to my car by the side door for a phone charger. Two minutes. Otherwise no.

PS O Did you hear anything from the dome?

IL Nothing. The dome motor is loud and the control room door was shut. I left at about three and drove to my lodgings.

PS O How did you get on with Professor Hale?

IL Very well. He was a generous colleague. He was reviewing my comet paper for me.

- TRANSCRIPT ENDS 14:58 -

DR M. OKAFOR - DEPUTY DIRECTOR

INTERVIEWEE	OKAFOR, M. (48)	DATE	08 JAN	COMMENCED	09:05
STATUS	WITNESS - BY TELEPHONE	INTERVIEWING	PS G. ORMEROD	LOCATED	GENEVA

- TRANSCRIPT BEGINS 09:05 -

PS O Where were you on the night of the sixth?

MO Geneva. I flew out on the fifth for a conference. I'm still here. I'll be back on Friday.

PS O You'll take over as director now.

MO Acting director. I know how that sounds. Edmund and I disagreed about plenty, but I would not have wished this on him.

PS O Did he have any worries recently?

MO He was troubled about something. He told me last week he'd found "a problem in somebody's data" and that he would have to deal with it before the journal did. He wouldn't say whose.

PS O Is the ladder dangerous?

MO Not for him. He wore a head torch and he never carried anything up it. Anything heavy went up on the hoist.

- TRANSCRIPT ENDS 09:19 -

E. HALE - WIFE OF THE DECEASED

INTERVIEWEE	HALE, E. (59)	DATE	07 JAN	COMMENCED	16:30
STATUS	WITNESS	INTERVIEWING	PS G. ORMEROD	ADDRESS	HALLOW LANE, 19 KM

- TRANSCRIPT BEGINS 16:30 -

PS O When did you last speak to your husband?

EH I rang him at quarter past twelve, on the dome phone. He sounded tired and pleased with himself. He said the seeing was the best all winter and he'd be home for breakfast.

PS O Did he mention anyone else?

EH He said, "I'm going to have a difficult conversation with Ivo before he goes." I didn't ask. He hated being asked.

PS O Where were you overnight?

EH At home, asleep. I'm on my own there when he's observing.

PS O There is a life insurance policy.

EH There is. Two hundred thousand. We took it out when we bought the house. You can look at whatever you like.

- TRANSCRIPT ENDS 16:44 -

K. NOWAK - DOCTORAL STUDENT

INTERVIEWEE	NOWAK, K. (26)	DATE	07 JAN	COMMENCED	12:10
STATUS	WITNESS	INTERVIEWING	PS G. ORMEROD	SUPERVISOR	PROF. E. HALE

- TRANSCRIPT BEGINS 12:10 -

PS O You were at the observatory yesterday evening.

KN I had the telescope from eight until half eleven for my variable stars, then Dr Lindqvist took over. I left about twenty to twelve and got the last bus.

PS O How was Professor Hale?

KN Strange. He and Dr Lindqvist had words in the corridor at about ten. Quiet words, but sharp. Edmund said, "Tonight, Ivo. Not tomorrow." Then he went up to the dome.

PS O Your thesis. Professor Hale was going to fail it?

KN He wanted another year of data. That's not failing. I was upset, I told people I was upset. I wasn't going to hurt him over it.

PS O Did you come back to the observatory at any point?

KN No. I was home by ten past twelve.

- TRANSCRIPT ENDS 12:21 -

MAIN DOME DOOR - LOCK EVENT LOG

KeyLine K-40 lock controller, door MD-1. Printed from the site console, 07 JAN 09:40, by user T.BRACKLEY. View: **FILTERED**. Period 06 JAN 18:00 to 07 JAN 09:00.

SEQ	TIMESTAMP	EVENT	SOURCE
#4468	06 JAN 18:00:00	SELF-TEST	CONTROLLER · OK
#4469	06 JAN 18:00:01	LATCH ARMED	CONTROLLER
#4470	06 JAN 21:58:10	OPEN	KEYPAD · CODE H (HALE)
#4471	06 JAN 21:58:31	CLOSED	DOOR SENSOR
#4478	07 JAN 07:31:05	OPEN	DOOR SENSOR · NO LATCH

Event count for period: **11**. The controller numbers every event in order. It records every keypad entry, every opening from inside (handle sensor) and every closing. The hand bolt on the inside is mechanical and is not recorded.

CODES ISSUED

CODE	HOLDER
H	Prof. E. HALE, director
O	Dr M. OKAFOR, deputy director
B	T. BRACKLEY, caretaker (also system administrator)
L	Dr I. LINDQVIST, visiting (issued 02 JAN)
N	K. NOWAK, student

The controller also sends every event to the manufacturer's cloud service, which keeps its own copy. Site users cannot edit the cloud copy.

TELESCOPE CONTROL LOG

Every command to the telescope mount is recorded with where it came from: the control-room software or the hand paddle on the platform in the dome.

TIME	SOURCE	EVENT
20:02:15	CONTROL ROOM	Session K.NOWAK. Slew to target field V1342.
23:31:50	CONTROL ROOM	Session K.NOWAK ends.
23:36:04	CONTROL ROOM	Session I.LINDQVIST. Slew to target C/2025-K4.
23:38:40	CONTROL ROOM	Imaging sequence started, 60 frames.
01:20:05	CONTROL ROOM	Imaging sequence complete, 60 of 60 frames.
01:31:40	HAND PADDLE (DOME)	Manual slew east.
01:37:12	HAND PADDLE (DOME)	Manual stop. Sidereal tracking resumed.
03:52:30	MOUNT	Horizon limit reached. Tracking halted automatically.
07:44:10	CONTROL ROOM	Session POLICE. Log exported.

No command of any kind was received between 01:37:12 and 03:52:30. A user at the telescope would normally stop the mount before it reaches the horizon limit.

MAIN BUILDING - CARD ACCESS LOG

Castlegate monitors the observatory's main entrance and its single side fire door. Both doors lock automatically. From outside, the main entrance opens only to a card; the side door does not open from outside at all. This system is run by Castlegate and cannot be changed by site staff.

TIMESTAMP	DOOR	EVENT
06 JAN 18:40:22	MAIN ENTRANCE	IN · E.HALE
06 JAN 19:45:09	MAIN ENTRANCE	IN · K.NOWAK
06 JAN 21:05:51	MAIN ENTRANCE	IN · I.LINDQVIST
06 JAN 23:41:05	MAIN ENTRANCE	OUT · K.NOWAK
07 JAN 00:46:58	SIDE FIRE DOOR	OPENED FROM INSIDE · ALARM
07 JAN 00:49:12	SIDE FIRE DOOR	CLOSED · ALARM RESET AUTOMATICALLY
07 JAN 03:05:44	MAIN ENTRANCE	OUT · I.LINDQVIST
07 JAN 07:02:30	MAIN ENTRANCE	IN · T.BRACKLEY
07 JAN 07:29:40	MAIN ENTRANCE	IN · POLICE (VISITOR CARD)

No card belonging to M. OKAFOR or E. HALE (Mrs) was presented in this period. The side fire door can be propped open from inside; it was not propped (sensor closed throughout except 00:46 - 00:49).

SCENE & EXHIBITS - MAIN DOME

E-1.1 · THE DOME DOOR

The hand bolt is intact and in the thrown (locked) position. The bolt keeper, the metal plate on the frame that receives the bolt, has been torn from the frame with its screws. The splintering of the frame is on the **inside face**. The pry marks from a flat bar are on the **inside edge of the door**. The outside face of the door and frame is undamaged.

Recorded as seen. No conclusion drawn by the original officer.

E-1.2 · EXHIBITS RECOVERED

REF	ITEM	LOCATION FOUND
EX-01	Brass telescope counterweight, 34 mm handle with knurled grip, one of a set of four	Counterweight rack, platform. The other three are dusty; this one is clean.
EX-02	Laptop, Prof. Hale, open, asleep, battery 9%	Platform desk
EX-03	Spectacles, Prof. Hale, one arm bent	Floor, under the platform
EX-04	Flat steel bar, 600 mm	Corridor outside the dome door
EX-05	Bolt keeper with two screws	Dome floor, inside the door

E-1.3 · THE LADDER

Vertical steel ladder, 2.4 m, rungs square-section with plain smooth edges. **No fitting on the ladder or platform rail carries a knurled or criss-cross surface.**